
RL.7.1

Citing Textual Evidence

Grade 7 ELA • Vocabulary, Strategies & Evidence Detective Practice

Be a text detective: every claim needs clues.



The Standard: RL.7.1

Standard

“Cite several pieces of textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly as well as inferences drawn from the text.”

What it means for students

- Use more than one piece of evidence — “several” means at least two or three.
- Support what the text states directly (explicit) and what it hints at (inference).
- Quote or paraphrase accurately, then explain how the evidence proves the point.
- Analysis is the goal — evidence without explanation is just a quote.

Key Vocabulary at a Glance

Vocabulary

1

analysis

Break it down to understand it

2

explicit

Stated clearly and directly

3

inference

A conclusion from evidence

4

text

Anything you read, view, or hear

5

textual evidence

Proof from inside the text

DEFINITION

A detailed examination of the components of a subject in order to understand its meaning and/or its nature as a whole.

EXAMPLE

Your analysis of the character Jonas shows he changes from obedient to rebellious — you looked at his words, his choices, and his silences, then explained what they add up to.

★ *Analysis = parts → pattern → meaning.*



Explicit / explicitly

Vocabulary

DEFINITION

Stated clearly and directly, leaving no room for confusion or interpretation.

EXAMPLE

The text states explicitly: “Maya had never missed a practice in three years.” You do not have to guess — the sentence says it outright.

★ *If you can point to the exact words, it’s explicit.*



Inference

Vocabulary

DEFINITION

A conclusion derived from logical reasoning following an investigation of the available evidence.

EXAMPLE

The text says Maya's hands shook and she read the letter twice. You infer she is nervous — the story never uses the word "nervous."

★ *Text clues + what you know = inference.*



DEFINITION

Anything that students can read, write, view, listen to, or explore — including books, photographs, films, articles, music, art, and more.

EXAMPLE

A short story, a documentary clip, a protest photograph, a song lyric, and a museum painting are all texts you can cite evidence from.



★ *A text is anything you can “read” closely.*

Textual evidence

Vocabulary

DEFINITION

Evidence found within a particular text, used to support or explain conclusions, opinions, and/or assertions about the text itself.

EXAMPLE

“She left the trophy on the bench and walked away” is textual evidence that the character no longer values winning.

★ *Quote it, cite it, then explain it.*



Strategy 1: Evidence Detectives

Strategy

The teacher gives you an inference and tells you how many clues you must find. Your job: prove it with textual evidence.

1

Read the inference

Know exactly what claim you must prove.

2

Hunt for clues

Scan the text for the required number of pieces of evidence.

3

Mark the evidence

Highlight or jot the exact words and where they appear.

4

Make your case

Explain how each clue proves the inference is accurate.

Detective rule: a clue only counts if you can point to it in the text.

Strategy 2: It Says – It Means – And So

Strategy

Use this three-column organizer to answer a text-dependent question.

It Says

List the piece of textual evidence — quote it exactly.

“Her hands shook as she opened the envelope.”

It Means

Explain what that evidence means in your own words.

Shaking hands show her body reacting to stress.

And So

State the inference you draw from the evidence.

So Maya is nervous about what the letter will say.

How to Cite Evidence in Writing

Sentence starters

- “The text states, ‘...’ which shows...”
- “For example, the author writes...”
- “Another piece of evidence is...”
- “Based on ‘...’ I can infer that...”
- “This suggests... because the text says...”

Check your evidence

- Did I use several pieces — not just one?
- Did I quote the text word for word?
- Does each quote actually prove my claim?
- Did I explain the evidence, not just drop it?
- Is my inference reasonable — or a wild guess?

Task Card 1: The Empty Locker

Practice

SHORT STORY

Devon spun the dial three times before the locker opened. His science binder was gone. On the shelf sat a folded note in handwriting he had seen on the whiteboard all year. He read it once, shoved it into his pocket, and did not open his mouth at lunch. When Ms. Reyes asked where his homework was, Devon stared at the floor and said he had lost it.

1. Which detail BEST supports the inference that Devon recognizes who took his binder?

- A. He spun the dial three times.
- B. The note is in handwriting he had seen all year.
- C. He did not speak at lunch.
- D. Ms. Reyes asked about his homework.

2. Which TWO details together suggest Devon is protecting someone?

- A. The locker opened and the binder was gone.
- B. He shoved the note in his pocket AND said he lost the homework.
- C. He read the note once AND spun the dial.
- D. He stared at the floor AND opened his locker.

Answer Key — Task Card 1

Answer Key

1. Which detail BEST supports the inference that Devon recognizes who took his binder?

Answer: B

WHY THIS EVIDENCE WORKS

“Handwriting he had seen on the whiteboard all year” directly links the note to someone Devon already knows. The other details show his reaction, not his recognition.

2. Which TWO details together suggest Devon is protecting someone?

Answer: B

WHY THIS EVIDENCE WORKS

Hiding the note and giving Ms. Reyes a false reason are two separate choices to conceal the truth — several pieces of evidence pointing to the same inference.

Push further: ask students to name a SECOND piece of evidence for each answer.

Task Card 2: Second Chair

Practice

SHORT STORY

The audition list went up at 7:40 a.m. Priya read her name beside “Second Chair” and smiled at Ms. Okafor. At home, she set her flute case by the door and did not touch it for four days. On Friday she told her mother the school was too crowded and asked about switching to art class. Her practice log, once full of red checkmarks, stayed blank.

1. What can the reader MOST reasonably infer from Priya's smile in the hallway?

- A. She is genuinely thrilled with second chair.
- B. She is hiding her disappointment in public.
- C. She did not read the list carefully.
- D. She dislikes Ms. Okafor.

2. Which piece of textual evidence BEST shows Priya's change in behavior?

- A. “The audition list went up at 7:40 a.m.”
- B. “She asked about switching to art class.”
- C. “Her practice log, once full of red checkmarks, stayed blank.”
- D. “Priya read her name beside ‘Second Chair.’”

Answer Key — Task Card 2

Answer Key

1. What can the reader MOST reasonably infer from Priya's smile in the hallway?

Answer: B

WHY THIS EVIDENCE WORKS

The smile is contradicted by everything that follows — the untouched case, the blank log, the request to switch classes. Evidence across the passage outweighs one moment.

2. Which piece of textual evidence BEST shows Priya's change in behavior?

Answer: C

WHY THIS EVIDENCE WORKS

The word “once” contrasts her past habit with her present one, making it the clearest evidence of change. Choice B is a result of the change, not proof of it.

Push further: ask students to name a SECOND piece of evidence for each answer.

Task Card 3: The Last Bus

Practice

SHORT STORY

Marcus checked the schedule twice, though he had it memorized. The 5:15 was the last bus that reached the hospital before visiting hours ended. When the coach announced an extra half hour of drills, Marcus laced his cleats and stayed. He texted, “Tell Grandpa I’ll come tomorrow.” At practice he missed three easy passes and asked to sit out the final scrimmage.

1. Which evidence supports the inference that Marcus regrets staying at practice?

- A. He checked the schedule twice.
- B. The coach announced extra drills.
- C. He missed three easy passes and asked to sit out.
- D. The 5:15 was the last bus.

2. What does the text state EXPLICITLY?

- A. Marcus loves his grandfather more than soccer.
- B. Marcus feels guilty about his decision.
- C. The 5:15 was the last bus to reach the hospital in time.
- D. Marcus will quit the team.

Answer Key — Task Card 3

Answer Key

1. Which evidence supports the inference that Marcus regrets staying at practice?

Answer: C

WHY THIS EVIDENCE WORKS

Uncharacteristic mistakes and pulling himself out of the scrimmage show his mind is elsewhere — an inference the text never states outright.

2. What does the text state EXPLICITLY?

Answer: C

WHY THIS EVIDENCE WORKS

Only choice C appears word for word in the passage. A, B, and D are inferences — reasonable, perhaps, but not directly stated.

Push further: ask students to name a SECOND piece of evidence for each answer.

Task Card 4: Sixty Seconds of Rain

Practice

SHORT STORY

The mural had taken the seventh grade eleven weeks. Ana arrived early on Monday and found the tarp folded neatly beside the wall, rain streaking the painted river into grey. She picked up the tarp, examined the tight, even folds, and looked toward the custodian's cart. Then she took a photograph of the wall, said nothing to her class, and asked the principal for a meeting.

1. Which detail BEST supports the inference that the tarp was removed on purpose?

- A. The mural took eleven weeks.
- B. Rain streaked the painted river grey.
- C. The tarp was folded neatly, in tight, even folds.
- D. Ana arrived early on Monday.

2. Which TWO actions together suggest Ana intends to build a case rather than accuse someone?

- A. She arrived early AND picked up the tarp.
- B. She took a photograph AND asked the principal for a meeting.
- C. She said nothing AND looked at the rain.
- D. She examined the folds AND left the wall.

Answer Key — Task Card 4

Answer Key

1. Which detail BEST supports the inference that the tarp was removed on purpose?

Answer: C

WHY THIS EVIDENCE WORKS

Wind or rain would not fold a tarp neatly. The deliberate folds are physical evidence that a person removed and folded it.

2. Which TWO actions together suggest Ana intends to build a case rather than accuse someone?

Answer: B

WHY THIS EVIDENCE WORKS

Photographing the wall preserves evidence, and requesting a meeting takes it to an authority — two steps that show a deliberate, evidence-based approach.

Push further: ask students to name a SECOND piece of evidence for each answer.

Wrap-Up: Your Evidence Checklist

Exit Ticket

Before you turn it in

- I made a clear claim or inference.
- I cited several pieces of textual evidence.
- I quoted the text accurately.
- I explained what each piece of evidence means.
- I connected the evidence back to my claim.

Exit Ticket

Choose any task card from today. Write ONE inference about the main character and support it with TWO pieces of textual evidence. Explain how each piece proves your inference.

Great detectives always show their clues.